"Even if you ask me years later, I'll remember this World Cup for the domination and intimidation of this Indian team over every other team," says Robin Uthappa, member of India's 2007 T20 World Cup-winning team. "They made all of us Indians feel invincible. The past 45 days have been exceptional for Indian cricket." Such sentiments are rarely expressed in cricket-mad India, especially when the country has been starved for an ICC title for over a decade. Yet, this time, that's exactly how 'bleed-blue' faithfuls seem to have responded to India's loss in the finals—perhaps a testament to how good the men in blue were throughout the tournament and the joy fans experienced.

## GREATEST TEAM NEVER TO WIN

At the 1954 FIFA Football World Cup in Switzerland, a rampaging and dominant Hungary took on a relatively unknown West Germany in the finals. Undefeated in 32 straight games, the 'Mighty Magyars' were odds-on favourites. Led by Ferenc Puskas, the best player on the planet at the time, Hungary had beaten West Germany 8-3 in the group stages. But no one accounted for German precision and resilience in the finals. Die Mannschaft fought back from a two-goal deficit to win 3-2. The press called it 'The Miracle of Bern'. Hungary in 1954 would go down as the greatest team never to have won the World Cup. Does the Hungary of 1954 compare with India in 2023?

In cricket history, seldom has a team steamrolled the opposition with such clinical precision at the sport's showpiece event as India did during this tournament. On the occasions that teams did dominate the event—West Indies in 1979 and Australia in 2007—they weren't as commanding as India's performance in the group stage of this edition, but they ended up lifting the trophy. In that respect, the 'reversal of Ahmedabad 2023' remains the closest reference point in cricket to the 'shocker of Bern in '54, where the mighty were upstaged at the final step.

## ROHIT: MAN WITH A PLAN

For 41 of the 42 days that the home team plied their trade at the 2023 World Cup, India's one-day template was the talk of the town. Whilst previous Indian T-20 teams had come in for criticism for being behind the curve—deservedly so, for being extra conservative in the sport's shortest format—their one-day approach in this World Cup did set a new benchmark. As England's 'Bazball' approach lay exposed as being one-dimensional and hence ineffective in Indian conditions, Australia's batting seemed hit and miss for most part—too dependent on individual brilliance rather than the well-oiled machine of the past. South Africa's vulnerabilities to chase under pressure became an open secret, while New Zealand's conventional approach, prompted by the lack of an 'x' factor in their batting, prevented them from pulling off the extraordinary. India, with their well-laid-out plans, clearly-defined roles for each batter and the devastating form of their bowlers, emerged as the pace-setters.

It all went back to that embarrassing loss to England in the semis

MOHAMMED SHAMI
TAKING FIFERS FOR FUN




***The fact that Mohammed Shami finished as the top wicket-taker in the World Cup despite sitting out the first four games is a testament to his blistering form. Shami was at his devastating best throughout—he took 24 wickets at an average of 10.70 and an economy of 5.26, including a seven-for in the semi-final vs New Zealand. His ability to get the ball to seam at will turned the world's best batsmen into nervous prodders***

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